

Inbound/Outbound ski between Falls Creek and BRC

Purpose

To travel between Falls Creek and the Bogong Rover Chalet on the commencing Saturday morning of winter party and return on the final Saturday morning of winter party.

Background

The BRC located on the Bogong High Plains road is a remote backcountry chalet. It is accessible, in winter, by an 11km relatively flat ski from Falls Creek via Langfords Gap and Langfords West aqueduct.

The BRC provides sleeping accommodation for up to 35 participants, typically on week long winter parties operating Saturday to Saturday. Winter party participants may range in age from 15 upwards and may include Venturers, Rovers and Leaders as well as non-Scout Movement members.

Participants are assumed to have sufficient fitness and ability to complete the 11km cross country ski from Falls Creek whilst carrying a full pack. However, the participants are not assumed to have any particular level of ski ability nor any ski experience.

For most participants, the inbound journey from Falls Creek to the BRC commences at Falls Creek Coach Service in Mt Beauty on the Saturday morning of winter party. Participants gather in time to park cars, load the week's allocation of fresh meat and vegetables into their packs and board the coach for Falls Creek. Most participants choose to stay the Friday night prior to winter party in accommodation in Mt Beauty organised by the BRC (currently Mt Beauty Scout Hall), though participants may organise their own accommodation and/or their own travel to Falls Creek.

The bus departs Falls Creek at approximately 7:30 am with arrival at Falls Creek at approximately 8:45am. There is a cross country ski shelter at Windy Corner, Falls Creek, that provides a final point of refuge including toilets, prior to commencing the journey to the BRC. At some point on the inbound journey, the party will pass the returning party from the previous week if there was one.

The return journey from the BRC to Falls Creek occurs on the following Saturday. Participants pack and clean the chalet in preparation for the incoming party and then set out for Falls Creek. The timing is so that all participants can safely make the departing bus, currently set at 10:45am, for the ride from Falls Creek to Mt Beauty where the winter party concludes. For slower, less capable participants, the departure time from the BRC can be before sunrise. At some point on the return journey, the party will pass the incoming party for the following week, if there is one.

A winter party at the BRC provides a youth training experience in which participants can be exposed to snow travel and an alpine experience in as safe an environment as possible. **An important aspect of the training experience is exposing participants to the conditions that can be encountered in an alpine environment whilst managing the risks. It is not an**

aim to avoid all risk but to use riskier situations to educate participants and provide experience in adverse conditions.

Location and route

Inbound – from Windy Corner carpark at Falls creek to BRC via Rocky Valley Dam, Watchbed Creek, Langfords Gap and the Langfords West Aqueduct. Distance: approx. 11km. Terrain: flat fire trail.

Outbound – reverse of inbound.

The stated route:

- Provides the flattest route, including maximum use of fire trails, thereby reducing risk of injury while carrying a pack, particularly for less experienced skiers
- Reduces the amount of navigation required
- Provides the greatest protection from weather in most circumstances
- Provides surety to the whip party that all skiers are in front of them and will be collected
- Allows the group to be fragmented so that participants may move at their own pace between the lead party and the whip party
- Passes Langfords Hut as a possible point of refuge.
- Has adequate mobile phone coverage

While in the past, the route has occasionally varied and parties have had the option of going over Basalt Hill and skiing down Home Slope or through Wallace's Gap, these variations in route are to be actively discouraged.

The journey is not inherently dangerous or arduous and can be safely navigated even during extremes of weather by a competent and experienced party. Of course, not all participants are competent and experienced. Because of the flow of one winter party to the next, including timings of food deliveries and bus bookings, there is a logistical imperative that each party skis into the BRC on the first Saturday morning and departs the BRC on the following Saturday morning to make way for the next party. The inbound and outbound journeys are thus viewed as a whole party team play with the sole goal of making sure all participants are safely delivered to and from the BRC. The imperative to undertake these journeys should never trump the requirement to avoid endangering the lives of participants.

General safety and considerations

The inward and outward journey from BRC shall comply with procedures set out in Bogong Rover Chalet Operations Manual (1) and comply with relevant Alpine SS&P (5). Sections relevant to the inward and outward journeys include:

- i. Minimum party size of four (4).
- ii. Leaders are encouraged to mentor other participants on the journey.
- iii. Stronger skiers are encouraged to assist lesser and newer skiers to ensure that all participants arrive at the BRC safely and in good spirits
- iii. At least two members of the party shall have current first aid qualifications (HLTAID011 or equiv.).
- vi. The party can break into groups. The lead-skier of each group should set a pace such that the group does not get too strung out. In fine weather with light breeze and unlimited visibility, the party can stretch out more. In conditions of higher winds and poor or limited visibility the party should be more compressed and line-of-sight maintained between lead-skier and tail-end-Charlie.
- x. If an injury occurs during the course of the journey that leaves the casualty immobilised, the group leader shall seek direct assistance from the relevant emergency service and inform the Party Leader or nominee at the BRC as to the situation.
- xi. Two sets of medical forms are to be carried into the chalet. A set of medical forms should be carried on tours. A soft copy of medical forms is held on the PL phone.

Participants

Unlike other activities at the chalet, the inbound and outbound journeys between Falls Creek and the BRC are compulsory and all participants of a winter party must travel the approx. 11km from Falls Creek to the BRC and return. Participants may include Rovers, Venturers and Leaders as well as non-movement members of all ages.

Participants are required to carry a pack and may be required to ski or hike depending on snow conditions, including in adverse weather. The participants are not assumed to have any particular level of ski ability nor any ski experience.

Participants are expected to have attended a Winter Party Briefing night prior to their first winter party. The briefing night provides guidance and instructions on gear and packing, the ski in, blister management, dealing with adverse weather, etc. Participants are thus considered to be informed as to the difficulty of skiing to the BRC and undertake the journey willingly.

All party members will be encouraged to obtain formal ski/snow qualifications. It is therefore expected that, over time, there will be a strong presence of participants having Trained Participant Cross Country Patrolled or Trained Participant Show Shoeing Day Tour qualification or Trained Participant Bushwalking Extremely Difficult Tracked & Untracked Environments or higher qualification (Guide).

Leadership

The BCMG will manage the party attendance list prior to the winter party to appoint an appropriate Party Leader (PL) and Party Adviser (PA) and to ensure that the party has sufficient group strength and experience to undertake the inbound journey to the BRC. This selection is based on collected data including number of previous winter parties attended, other attendances at the BRC and other skiing and outdoor experience more generally. First Aid qualification is also collected. The BCMG will add participants to the group to ensure an adequate ratio of experienced to novice participants.

The PL and PA will each have minimum 3 winter parties if they have attended nob's training and/or additional working bees. If the PL and PA has not attended nob's training and/or additional working bees, the PL and PA will have attended a minimum of 4 winter parties.

When considering the inbound and outbound journeys, the PL/PA must consider forecast weather conditions, snow conditions, party size and ability and monitor how conditions and the condition of party members tracks throughout the journey. While the inbound/outbound routes and timings are not amendable to much change, discretion should be exercised to ensure that the party is not subject to dangerous and life threatening conditions – dynamic risk management.

The inbound and outbound journeys to/from the BRC carry the usual risks of injury and equipment failure associated with skiing. These are addressed in the Emergency Management section below and in the associated Risk Assessment document, also referenced below.

The PL/PA will introduce themselves to first time participants on the Friday night prior to winter party and assess the participants' readiness for the winter party.

The PL/PA will collect a bothy shelter from Mount Beauty Scout hall. This is to be carried by the experienced participants at the tail end of the group?

The PL/PA will divide the group to appoint:

- **Only** if there is enough experience in the group to not be robbing the remainder of competent mentors, a party of at least 6 fast skiers may be selected to go ahead to open the chalet and then return to assist slower participants
- A whip party capable of escorting the slowest participants to the chalet and designated as the last group to arrive at the chalet. The safety pack will be distributed to the whip party.

Considerations specific to inbound journey

The compulsory nature of the inbound journey presents challenges that are not present for other aspects of the winter party including:

- Unknown fitness and abilities of participants
- Unknown/untested gear

- The imperative to complete the journey on the first Saturday of winter party irrespective of conditions
- Forced exposure in adverse conditions where the participant might otherwise stay in shelter

These additional risks can manifest as:

- Slow party leading to increased fatigue and exposure of all present
- Slow party leading to increased time carrying pack, increased blisters and risk of back related injuries
- Inability or unwillingness of participants to continue
- Inability for participant to be self-sufficient on journey
- Increased risk of hypothermia and dangers of being cold/wet
- Increased sun exposure

These risks can be managed by:

- PL/PA review party list prior to winter party to identify less experienced participants
- PL/PA seek out less experienced participants prior to journey, e.g. at Scout Hall Friday night, to discuss any issues and confidence levels prior to skiing in, ensure participant has adequate gear, not excessive pack weight. Can delegate to other experienced party members
- Appointing a faster group of competent participants to undertake journey to the BRC quickly, open up the chalet (set fires and warm drinks) and return with additional food and drink and with empty packs to assist slower participants and relieve accompanying participants.
- Appoint one or more strong/competent participants to accompany the slower participants.
- Appoint a whip as the absolute last participant of the journey.
- Ensure all participants are sure of the route to BRC and/or are buddied up with someone who is sure of the route
- If weather is bad, ensure that all participants are prepared for conditions prior to departing Windy Corner.
- Divert to shelter at Langfords hut to rest and recover in shelter and shelter from the weather. Sleeping bags can be used for warmth. Head torches can be used to complete the journey in the dark if required.
- Redistribute pack loads to ease burden on slower participants and to help manage blisters
- Encourage those affected to stop and manage blisters and sore spots early before it is too late. Better to have pre-taped suspect rubbing points prior to departure
- Manage fatigue with sufficient food, water and rest stops.
- Provide whip party with safety pack including bothy tent and first aid kit
- Return to Falls Creek/Windy Corner if safer than continuing onwards
- Enact contingency plan if weather is unsafe for any/all participants to travel.

- Trigger point can be a blizzard/high wind forecast corroborated by on-snow reporting. Preparations for enacting the contingency plan can be made using 3-day BOM forecast. Falls Creek Coaches and Road Closure information can be useful indicators.
- Contingency plan will manage, via the management group:
 - Additional accommodation in Mt Beauty and/or Falls Creek
 - Alternative bus transport to Falls Creek when weather has improved
 - Storage of fresh meat and vegetables until required.
- Contingency plan will have a discretionary component. If the party has sufficient experience and is willing to undertake the journey, the PL/PA allow some or all of the party to undertake the journey. This recognises that adverse conditions can provide a useful training and experience point for participants. Under no circumstances will participants be forced or coerced to undertake the journey if the contingency plan triggers are met. If contingency plans are met, any decision to travel into the BRC will be coordinated with the outbound travel plans of the incumbent winter party.

Considerations specific to outbound journey

The outbound journey presents challenges that are not present for other aspects of the winter party including:

- Requirement to complete outbound journey in time for the bus
- Requirement to ski with minor injuries, including blisters
- Requirement to undertake the journey with faulty gear
- The imperative to exit the BRC irrespective of conditions to make way for incoming party

These additional risks can manifest as:

- Slow party leading to increased fatigue and exposure of all present
- Slow party leading to increased time carrying pack, increased blisters and risk of back related injuries
- Inability or unwillingness of participants to continue
- Inability for participant to be self-sufficient on journey
- Forced exposure in adverse conditions where the participant might otherwise stay in shelter

These risks can be managed by:

- PL/PA review party list prior to exit to identify likely slower participants
- Manage loads of slower participants and redistribute to stronger participants where required
- Create departure plan on Friday night that gives all participants ample time to complete journey

- Consider walking in shoes to avoid/manage blisters, if safe to do so. Allow extra time if necessary.
- Get updated weather forecast (BOM)
- Consider evacuating anyone who can't complete the journey on an earlier day, including sorting transport and accommodation logistics by communicating with Management Group
- Appoint a fast party to do final chalet lock up and act as whip for party
- Ensure all groups are sure of the route to Falls Creek
- If weather is bad, ensure that all participants are prepared for conditions prior to departing BRC.
- If departure is in dark, ensure participants have adequate head torch, borrow from later departing participants if necessary
- Divert to shelter at Langfords hut to rest and recover in shelter and shelter from the weather. Sleeping bags can be used for warmth.
- Redistribute pack loads to ease burden on slower participants and to help manage blisters
- Encourage those affected to stop and manage blisters and sore spots early before it is too late.
- Manage fatigue with sufficient food, water and rest stops.
- Return to BRC if safer than continuing onwards and phone Warden and/or incoming party to advise
- Enact contingency plan if weather is unsafe for any/all participants to travel.
 - Trigger point can be a blizzard/high wind forecast corroborated by on-snow reporting. Preparations for enacting the contingency plan can be made using 3-day BOM forecast. Falls Creek Coaches and Road Closure information can be useful indicators.
 - Contingency plan will manage, via the management group:
 - Alternative bus transport from Falls Creek to Mt Beauty when weather has improved
 - Coordination of incoming party for following week
 - Contingency plan will have a discretionary component. If the party has sufficient experience and is willing to undertake the journey, the PL/PA allow some or all of the party to undertake the journey. This recognises that adverse conditions can provide a useful training and experience point for participants. Under no circumstances will participants be forced or coerced to undertake the journey if the contingency plan triggers are met. If a group is to remain at the BRC, that group shall have a minimum of 4 persons and have sufficient experience, strength and competence to undertake the journey to Falls Creek when the conditions have improved.

Risk Management

See separate "Risk assessment – inbound_outbound.xlsx"

The alpine environment presents a number of hazards. The selection of the route between Falls Creek and BRC avoids common potential snow hazards such as steep slopes, snow bridges, avalanche zones, etc. However, the usual alpine weather factors still persist including blizzards, poor visibility, hyperthermia, bright sunlight, sun exposure, altitude. In addition, even gentle slopes can present a hazard for novice skiers carrying a full pack.

The notable terrain hazards are at Langfords Gap, the slopes adjacent Basalt Hill in the region of Lat/Long () and the areas of the open aqueduct more generally.

At Langfords Gap, a stretch of approximately 100m, the fire trail narrows, is rocky and the snow is very often patchy. If icy, the slope can be particularly difficult to negotiate. Participants are encouraged to remove skis and negotiate this area on foot. Less capable participants can be assisted with their skis and pack.

At Basalt Hill, the normally level fire trail accumulates snow and provides a cross slope that must be traversed. The cross slope can be particularly difficult when conditions are icy. While there is a slope, the slope is not sufficient to create a runaway event requiring a participant to self arrest. If required, a participant can walk this section and can be assisted with their skis and pack. It should be noted that the likelihood of this section being icy increases from 3pm onwards as the sun lowers.

Sections of the aqueduct are open and provide the potential for participants to fall in. Participants are warned of the open areas and encouraged to ski more than a body width away from the edge.

For general hazards of the ski journey, the participants may be supported as follows:

Personal support

- Redistribute load
- Provide food and water
- Provide sunscreen and eye protection from other participants if inadequate
- Consider walking in suitable shoes instead of skiing/walking in boots to manage blisters
- Carry packs of less experienced participants on any slopes to help the participant manage speed and prevent injury

Group support

- Consider splitting party into groups to manage the slow participants while allowing faster participants to complete the journey at their own speed.
- Have faster party members return to assist slower participants and to share the role of supporting the slower participants.
- Help participants to address blisters.

If trip is taken during poor weather, additional measures should be taken including:

- Keep group together in sight
- Actively check participant energy levels and hypothermia

- Consider use of huts on route (e.g. Langfords) as a warm up stop or to wait out the worst of the weather.
- Use naturally sheltered points on route for rest stops (usually Watchbed Creek and points along aqueduct)
- In extreme cases, return to starting point (Falls Creek or BRC) and enact Contingency Plan as necessary.
- Request assistance if a participant is unable to continue to destination (e.g. injury, hypothermia).

Emergency management

If a participant requires immediate medical attention, call 000.

If a participant requires evacuation, but it is not urgent, call the police or SES at Falls Creek to discuss possible arrangements.

Request assistance from the chalet if the emergency can be managed with additional people and/or equipment.

Contact the chalet if there is any emergency.

Consider whether to manage an injured or incapacitated person without moving, move to a nearby hut, return/continue to Falls Creek, or continue/return to the chalet.

Rescue equipment available at the chalet includes snowshoes, roll up stretcher, blankets, sleeping bag, tarpaulin. For the inbound and outbound journeys, each participant will have a sleeping bag and warm clothing as part of their gear for the week.

If emergency services are called, or a person requires immediate medical treatment, you must contact the Scouts Victoria Emergency Line 03 8543 9877. A Scouts Victoria incident report will need to be submitted within 48 hours of the end of the trip. Keep notes to assist with preparing this incident report. The chalet warden Matt Anderson [REDACTED] should also be notified.

Emergency numbers

Bogong Rover Chalet [REDACTED]

Bogong Rover Chalet Warden Matt Anderson [REDACTED]

Scouts Victoria Emergency Line 03 8543 9877

Scouts Victoria State Leader Alpine, Peter Robinson [REDACTED]

FOR ALL EMERGENCIES CALL 000

Ski Patrol 03 5758 3502

Search & Rescue 03 5758 3213

Falls Creek Medical Centre 03 5758 3238

Mount Beauty Medical Centre 03 5758 3400

Falls Creek Police Station 03 5758 3424

SES at Windy Corner 03 5758 3432 or 13 25 00.

Inbound Outbound Ski Between Falls Creek and the Chalet

Version: 2024

Hospitals:

- Alpine Health Mount Beauty, 2-8 Hollonds St, Mount Beauty, 03 5754 3500.
- Northeast Health Wangaratta, 35-57 Green St, Wangaratta 03 5722 5111. 24-hour emergency department.
- Albury Wodonga Health, 53-81 Vermont St, Wodonga, 02 6051 7111. 24-hour emergency department.